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FROG HYMNS AND RAIN BABIES
Monsoon Culture and the Art of Ancient South Asia

Gautama V. Vajracharya
with a Foreword by Pratapaditya Pal

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Captions

Cover: (front) Gajalakshmi, lotus vine, and turtle. See page 199.

(back) Lumhiti, Patan. Photograph: Julia A.B. Hegewald.

Page 1: River goddess on *makara*. See page 196.

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Page 7: Buddha. See page 61; foliate ram. See page 115.



Creatures of the Rain-River and Cloud-Lakes

The magnificent works of the Newar artists and architects of the Kathmandu valley include not only paintings, sculptures, residential houses, public buildings, and royal palaces but also water fountains positioned in public places near residential areas or inside palaces. These fountains have been studied on several occasions,¹ but we approach the subject here from a different point of view and present a novel study on their artistic significance and the meaning of the various creatures sumptuously carved on their spouts.

Most of the fountains that have survived in the valley belong to the medieval period (879–1769 CE), but some were created in the 7th century and even earlier. The symbolic creatures associated with the iconography of the fountain also appear on the stone sculptures of Bharhut, Sanchi, Bodhgaya, and other archaeological sites in India, and more meaningfully in the ceiling paintings of Ajanta. The earliest examples date to the 2nd century BCE. Textual evidence, however, indicates that the concepts associated with the fountains and their symbolic creatures are actually much older even than the earliest appearance of the creatures in South Asian art. We begin with some important information regarding the ancient Newars, their homeland, and the inherent similarity of their culture with the monsoon-based agrarian culture of the rest of South Asia. This will be followed by a study of the symbolism of the fountains, where we expect to find clues to understand the relation between the enduring concept of the age-old aestivation/monsoon culture and the carvings of creatures on the spouts. We will conclude with a study of two different artistic motifs, *pokkharasataka*, “perched on a lotus”, and a flowering vinelike

recurring theme, *dharankura*, “rain-sprout”, both of which provide further evidence for the continuity of monsoonal culture in Nepal.

The Newars of Kathmandu Valley

The Kathmandu valley is located almost in the middle of Nepal between the Mahabharat mountain range and the snow-capped Himalaya. According to popular legend the valley was a lake that became inhabitable only after the Bodhisatva Manjushri cut a channel through the surrounding hills and drained out the lake’s waters. The alluvial soil found in the valley and the rich vocabulary of fish and other aquatic creatures in the classical literature of the Newars indicate that this story may have some basis in an actual event. Although Tibetans call them Bal-po, “wool people”, the Newars identify themselves as Neva or Nawa. Almost certainly, the term Neva derives from the Tibeto-Burman word *nhet.pa (nepa)*, which means cowherd.²

Very likely the Nevas migrated to the valley from Nuwakot, a region situated to the northwest of the valley.³ The Sanskritized name of the region is Navakota, new fort. Although this Sanskrit name was in vogue even in the 14th century,⁴ originally the village was named after the Nevas. A label inscription in a maplike horizontal scroll painting, currently in the collection of the Philadelphia Museum of Art, designates this place as Nevakuti, “the village of the Nevas”. This information corresponds with Tibetan historical sources such as the *Blue Annals*, which identify the region as Bal-po rdzon meaning “the village of the Nevas”.⁵ In addition to Nevakuti several other archaic names for the rivers and localities found in the paintings, such as Sirukhu for the Trishula

Gandaki, and Tagvarapha for the slope of the high mountain near the Gandaki river, suggest that this 18th-century scroll painting and the epigraphic text are a copy of a much earlier work of a Newar artist.

We have demonstrated in earlier chapters that the pre-Vedic concept of the rain child was an important aspect of the ancient agrarian culture. This concept survived latently in Newar culture, which we will discuss here briefly and in more detail in the following chapter. The Newars were well acquainted with the ancient custom of the annual celebration of Vishuvat (the Vedic word for both the vernal and the autumnal equinox),⁶ which is designated as Bishika or Bishaka in classical Newari. The Newars still celebrate the vernal equinox by erecting a cosmic pole, symbolizing both time and space.⁷ The main significance of the celebration is completely lost because, due to the precession of the equinoxes, the day of the vernal equinox has gradually shifted within the last three millennia. Currently the equinox takes place on March 21, but the Newars, following ancient custom, celebrate the vernal equinox on the first day of Vaishakha in summer as the new year's day of the Vikrama era (April 13 in 2012). In Kerala this new year's day is known as Vishu. Neither the Newars nor the people of Kerala seem to be aware of the real meaning of the word and its relation to the significance of the day. According to Vedic scholars it is possible that during

the early Vedic period (c. 1500–1200 BCE), the summer and winter solstices corresponded with the present-day autumnal and vernal equinoxes respectively.⁸ This possibility needs to be studied carefully keeping in mind the Newars' traditional celebration of Vishuvat in April. This is indeed one of the reasons that invites us to investigate the ancient history of Newar culture more deeply.

The Sanskrit-speaking people of ancient India called Newar people Nipa, probably a variation of Neva. Thus, Nepala or Naipala means the house of the Nipas in Sanskrit. One of the Vedic rishis responsible for composing several Rigvedic hymns was given the epithet Nipatithi, Nipa's guest, indicating his familiarity and friendship with the Nipas, and that he might have lived in the foothills of the Himalaya or visited the region regularly.

Linguistic evidence provides the probable location of the early settlement of the Newars in the valley. In classical Newari, the mother-tongue of the Newars, the Vagmati river is known as Tekho, eastern river, whereas the Icchamati rivulet is Ikho, western river.⁹ Thus we assume they settled down in a narrow strip of land in the vicinity of Hadigaun (also spelt Hadigaon), an ancient town located between these two water sources.

Despite the fact that the Newari language belongs to the Tibeto-Burman family, a comparative study of classical Newari (earlier than the 14th century) with modern Newari clearly reveals that within less than a millennium this language borrowed a huge number of Sanskrit words. One might expect to see a similar phenomenon in the development of the Newar culture of the valley, but the story is not that simple. Most of the similarities between the culture of the Kathmandu valley and that of other parts of the Indian subcontinent are not the result of external influence, but stem from the distinct age-old culture that they shared with the rest of the subcontinent. Like the culture of India, that of the valley originated from the agrarian way of life based on the annual phenomena of aestivation and monsoon. Unlike the Tibetan plateau, Nepal

7.1
Lomhiti, Kumbheshvara, Patan, date unknown, the original construction may go back to the Licchavi period (200–879 CE). Photograph: author.



is situated on the windward side of the high Himalayan mountain ranges that block the path of the monsoon clouds. Thus, when the Newar Buddhists of the Kathmandu valley practise the rainy season retreat or perform the puja ritual of Vasudhara, the yellow goddess of rice paddy,¹⁰ one can see the pragmatic aspect of the rituals. The same rituals, when performed in Tibet, lose their practical significance.

Unlike the Indian plains, the valley remained largely isolated from direct contact with other civilizations for many centuries because of the hills and the malarial jungle that lie between the Indian plains and central Nepal. This isolation helped the inhabitants of the valley to protect their land from foreign invasions and direct influence. This is one of the reasons that Buddhism survived here side by side with Hinduism almost as in pre-Islamic India. In fact, not only Buddhism but also some elements of the enduring aestivation/monsoon culture, sometimes forgotten in other parts of South Asia, remained almost intact in the culture of the valley.

While the people from the Indian plains might have had trouble visiting the Himalayan regions, the Newars from a very early time knew that the malarial jungle could be crossed safely during winter. Kautilya's *Arthashastra* 2.11.101 refers to a woollen blanket called *bhingsi*, almost certainly a Newari word for "woollen cloth of fine quality" (*si* = cloth), as a collectable Nepali product for a king's treasure. Usually in the ancient world, as we know from multiple *Jataka* stories such as the *Baveru* (Babylonian)-*jataka* (no. 339), a collector would buy exotic goods from merchants who came to the threshold of their customers' region to sell their merchandise. Through such direct contact, Nepal might have been familiar with many aspects of the contemporaneous developments of ancient culture in the Indian plains. Admittedly, some similarities that we see between Newar culture of the valley and Indian culture originated from such contact. As we know from inscriptions of the Licchavi period (c. 200–879 CE), the Indianization of the valley

was also related to this sophisticated and powerful dynasty's policy of ruling the country with an Indic system and values. For instance, in the 7th century a Licchavi king introduced a new system of law and order that lowered the social status of indigenous women who exercised the freedom of divorce, even though their ethnic group traditionally permitted them to do so.¹¹

As in other parts of the Indian subcontinent, the initial culture of the valley did go through multiple layers of development, particularly when it became familiar with the exotic foreign elements that had gained popularity in the neighbouring region. Due to the isolated location of the valley, new elements arrived there with some delay and continued to survive for a considerable period, even centuries after some of these elements were completely forgotten in India. This tendency to preserve earlier heritage, not allowing it to be replaced by new elements, is indeed the main reason that aspects of monsoon culture are still more discernible in Newar heritage than in India.

However, the earliest textual references to the aestivation/monsoon culture, as we demonstrated in earlier chapters, are found in Vedic literature. Strictly speaking, the Vedic materials that we will be using here are not originally Indo-Iranian but rather elements of the aestivation/monsoon culture of South

7.2

Lumhiti and Nagaya Pukhu (Serpent's Tank), Bhaktapur Durbar Square, 1688. Photograph: author.



Asia well preserved in Vedic literature. In other words, we find the literature helpful for understanding Newar art and culture not because the Newars are Vedic people, but because the literature contains multiple elements of the aboriginal people of South Asia as exemplified by the custom of frog worship (see Chapter 1). Although this custom is not to my knowledge prevalent in India any more,¹² the Newars still worship the frogs for rain and the success of their rice harvest.

Depending on the flow of rivulets or rivers, Newars usually classify their cities or towns as *thane* and *kone* which literally mean upward and downward, respectively. But these words are also used to designate north and south, respectively, which is logical since most rivers in the Kathmandu valley originate in the north and eventually flow southwards. In a 7th-century Licchavi inscription a town situated at the southern border of the valley on a Himalayan slope is designated as *Thamtumri*, a cognate of the ancient/medieval Newari words *thamthu* and *thane*.¹³ Likewise, princes coming from the Indian plains are described in the *Gopalarajavamshavali* (46 *kha*, 53 *kha*), a 14th-century chronicle, as *kovane gaharapam*, or *kovanam bijyana*, “coming from the lower region, or south”. In fact the word *kone* is still used in Newari for the plains of India.

In a Rigvedic hymn (10.98.5–6), just as in Newari, upper and lower regions are distinguished as *uttara* and *adhara*, respectively. As mentioned earlier, the rain-river flows down from the Upper Ocean (*uttara samudra*) to the Lower Ocean (*adhara samudra*). People in ancient India saw the similarity between the shower of rain and river because both flow down from an upper region, *uttara*. But *uttara* also means north as in Uttarakuru, because the northern regions of India are noticeably higher owing to the presence of the Himalaya mountain range. Thus, north is closer to atmosphere and heaven. As we will see shortly, the Vedic people travelled from south to north with the purpose of reaching a heavenly location. However it is unlikely that these Sanskrit-speaking people

introduced this concept, as it is closely linked to the geography of northern India. In fact, in the *Avesta* the heavenly kingdom of Yima is situated in the south, while the foul-smelling region that belongs to the demonic Daivas is in the north. Undoubtedly the concept of north as “the upper region or heaven” is a pre-Vedic notion prevalent among indigenous peoples who lived close to the Himalayan regions, such as the Newars. So far as I know, in India cities and towns are not divided into upper and lower regions any longer; this pre-Vedic concept is completely forgotten even around the Punjab region, but it has remained intact in the Kathmandu valley among the Newars.

Perhaps the most striking example of the archaic element in Newar culture is the custom of *vahla* (or *vala*, *wahla*, *bohla*) *chvanegu*. Like frog worship, this ceremony is still practised by Jyapus, the Newar farmers of the valley also known as Maharjans. It is observed by males between the ages of nine and 22, just before the tuition session of music and dance which begins during the rainy season on the 14th day of the dark half of Shravana (July/August). The ceremonial rite is repeated for three years. At the end of the ceremony but before the tuition begins the maternal uncle of the young farmer boy offers his newly initiated nephew a special homemade piece of cotton cloth called *paua*.¹⁴ The meaning of *pau* is not clear to me, but the second word *ga* is a Newari synonym for a shawl.

Comparing this ceremony with the ancient *upanayana* rite, we see that *vahla chvanegu* is the ritual of “initiation to solemn study”. Here we need to know that the original *upanayana* was very different from the modern-day sacred-thread ceremony. The sacred thread, for instance, originally was not a thread but a garment, worn diagonally in accordance with the ancient school of South Asia, covering the left shoulder; hence, it was called *upavita*.¹⁵ The *paua* of the *vahla chvanegu* ceremony is actually identical with the original *upavita*. It is worn in the same manner. In modern times, the *upanayana* ceremony can be performed any time

of the year if the astrologer can find a *muhurta*, an auspicious time for the ceremony. But in the early Vedic period *upanayana* was a seasonal ritual signifying the beginning of intensive study during the rainy season. Thus, the first day of *upanayana* coincided with the croaking of the frogs and the growth of vegetation in the month of Shravana, as we discussed in Chapter 1. The Newar session of music and dance study also takes place at almost the same time of year. Furthermore, in accordance with the academic custom recorded in Vedic literature, the disciple is considered a foetus conceived by the teacher. This was so real to the ancient people that the solemn rituals of conception and birth were performed at the beginning and end of the school session.¹⁶ The Newar ceremony of *vahla chvanegu* is also based on the same concept because the Newari words literally mean “staying (like) a foetus”.¹⁷ Due to the direct association of the original *upanayana* rites with the typical monsoonal phenomena of South Asia and their survival in the utterly non-Vedic rituals of the Newar farmers, we can conclude that, just like frog worship, or the concept of north/upper and south/lower, although recorded in Vedic literature, they are actually pre-Vedic elements of South Asia. Thus, the similarities that we see in Vedic and Newar rites should not be considered as Hindu or Vedic influence as in reality the rites are pre-Vedic customs of the age-old monsoon culture. They have survived in Newar tradition in a form much closer to their origins than in the modern-day Hindu ritual of the sacred thread. In the following pages, I intend to present similar examples, mainly from the artistic heritage of the Newars.

As stated in the Introduction, the use of Vedic materials for understanding South Asian art is not new. Many decades ago, great scholars such as A.K. Coomaraswamy, Stella Kramrisch, Heinrich Zimmer, and V.S. Agrawala used the materials to explain the significance of South Asian art. Nevertheless, these scholars, to my knowledge, have not satisfactorily answered an important question. Despite a huge time difference, and the discontinuance of important



Vedic rituals such as the horse sacrifice long before the Gupta period (c. 320–647 CE), why is it logical to use Vedic materials (1500–600 BCE) to explain South Asian art of a much later period, even for the early classical period that begins around the 3rd century BCE? The answer to this question comes from the pre-Vedic aestivation/monsoon culture and its close association with the artistic expression of South Asia.

Hiti and Hitimanga

The Kathmandu valley is dotted with fountains within sunken bathing places, often arranged in terraces (figures 7.1–7.4). In general, such

7.3
Thusa-hiti, Patan Durbar Square, 1646. Photograph: author.

7.4
Royal fountain, Hanumandhoka palace, Kathmandu, 1652. Photograph: author.



7.5
Lumhiti, Taumadhi Tol,
Bhaktapur, c. 15th century.
Photograph: author.



7.6
Public fountain south of
Mangal Bazar, Patan, 7th
century CE. Photograph:
author.

a place is called *hiti*, whereas the spout of the fountain is known to the Newars as *hitimanga* (Sanskrit *dhara-makara*, *makara* fountain) or simply *dhara*. The fountains are also designated as *lomhiti*, stone fountain, or *lumhiti*, golden fountain, in reference to the medium of the spouts of the fountains and their repousse covers, respectively, both of which are designed like a *makara* with a wide-open mouth, vomiting out a stream of water (figure 7.5). The main characteristic of the *makara* spout is the so-called foliage motif, which appears along the elongated body of the mythical creature. This motif is both decorative and symbolic.

Usually on the terrace just above the fountain, statues of Hindu and Buddhist divinities including Shivalinga and monolithic shrines or *chaityas* are found (figure 7.6, and see figure 7.3). Apparently, the terrace represents a region close to the celestial world. Depending upon the devotion of the donor, images of Shiva and Parvati or Vishnu and Lakshmi are placed immediately above the spout, sometimes in a typical *kirtimukha* shrine. Perhaps even more noteworthy are the stone sculptures representing a *yaksha* or a pair of *yakshas* on the wall below the spout (figures 7.5 and 7.7). The *yakshas* are shown as if lifting a mountain on their shoulders. Quite often, however, in the same location we see a statue of Bhagiratha, the mythical prince responsible for bringing the celestial river Ganga down to the earth (figure 7.8, and see figure 7.21). We believe these different portrayals elucidate two layers of development in the symbolism of the water fountains of the valley.

Most of the fountains are simple, having only essential elements such as the *makara* spout and the image of *yakshas* or Bhagiratha. But some of them are much more elaborately designed, as exemplified by the golden fountains in the three royal palaces of the valley. Perhaps the best example is Jitamitra Malla's (ruled c. 1673–96) contribution in his Bhaktapur palace (figure 7.9). It shows a huge head of a *makara* with its voluminous trunk raised upward. The *makara* has large eyes, curly snout, and short legs. On top of the spout, just behind the trunk, crawls an iguanalike creature. Both sides of the spout are crowded with aquatic and semiaquatic creatures such as crocodiles, ducks, turtles, frogs, and snakes as well as domesticated animals such as horses, goats, and cows (figure 7.10). Note also the conchshell near the foot of the *makara*. The human figure with bird's feet and tail is a *kinnara*, but in illustrated Newar iconographic texts this mythical figure is identified as *jalamanusha*, aquatic man.¹⁸

From the open jaws of the *makara* emerges a cow or a bull. This is a fascinating iconographic element of the Newar fountains. The Kathmandu



palace fountain (see figure 7.4) displays several bulls jumping out of the *makara*'s wide-open mouth. The Bull or Calf Fountain (*thusa-hiti*) in the Sundari Chok of the Patan palace (figure 7.22) is actually named after this iconographic element.¹⁹ The element is not, however, restricted to palatial fountains; the discharge of a bull or calf from a *makara*'s mouth is also found in several other examples of fountains (figure 7.11).

Epigraphic evidence indicates that some elements of water architecture go back to the Licchavi period or to the transitional period that followed (c. 879–1200). The water fountain of Mangal Bazaar in Patan (figure 7.12), for instance, was originally a contribution of Bharavi, the grandson of the famous Licchavi king Manadeva, who ruled around 464–505.²⁰ The Sankhu fountain (see figure 7.7) was built in 1168.²¹ Most of the surviving examples are, however, the creations of the Malla period (c. 1200–1769). During this long period of history, the valley-dwellers developed admirable skills and techniques to bring water from considerable distances. An unpublished Sanskrit text entitled *Varishastra*, "Treatise on Water", describes how to build such fountains. This short text is currently preserved in the collection of the National Archives in Kathmandu. It was possibly composed in the valley, because some parts are related to the technical and artistic features of the fountains of the valley.

The *makara* fountain was not confined to Nepali water architecture. Although such fountains, to my knowledge, do not exist anywhere in India any more, the 7th-century poet Bana describes water



7.7

Yakshas below *hiti* near Vajrayogini temple, Sankhu, 1168 CE. Photograph courtesy Mary Slusser.

7.8

Bhagiratha below *hitimanga*, Patan, c. 18th century. Photograph: author.

spouts made of ivory and designed like the *makara*'s mouth at the end of water channels (*dantamayamakaramukhamahapranala*) in the royal bathing places in the palace of Harshavardhana, the Hindu emperor whose life and times the poet described in his *Harshacharita*.²² This textual evidence also suggests that very likely the Newar fountains found in 17th- and 18th-century Malla palaces are palatial features from a much earlier time, going back to Licchavi-period Nepal.

Most of the *yaksha* images found below the spouts (figure 7.13) can be dated on stylistic grounds to a much earlier period than most of the images of the prince Bhagiratha. This may suggest that the image of the prince is a development of a later period. But there is at least one example of a Bhagiratha image that belongs to a much earlier period, almost certainly the 7th or 8th century (figure 7.14). Here the prince is shown standing, hands folded

7.9

Hitimanga, detail of *lumhiti*, Bhaktapur palace fountain, 1688. Photograph: author.



7.10
Detail of figure 7.9, creatures
depicted on the *hitimanga*,
Bhaktapur palace, 1688.
Photograph: author.



in the *namaskara* gesture. As usual, in order to indicate the prince's long practice of austerity, he is shown bearded. According to a popular myth, Bhagiratha was not able to perform the cremation ritual of his ancestors due to a lack of water on the earth. Only after he was able to bring the celestial river Ganga down to earth could he perform the ritual. Thus, the presence of Bhagiratha below the fountain suggests that the *makara* spout and the stream of the water flowing from the mouth of the mythical creature represents the Ganga's descent from the heavens.

The religious calendar of the subcontinent informs us that the Ganga descended on the 10th day of Jyeshtha Shukla, known to astrologers and people of the subcontinent as Ganga Dasara.²³ In astrological texts such as the *Brihatsamhita* (23.1–10), technically this time of the year (May/June) is designated as *pravarshana*, pre-monsoonal rain, an important

7.11
Hitimanga of the *lomhiti* on
the southwest slope of Changu
hill, c. 10th century CE.
Photograph: author.



time for the agrarian society of the subcontinent; rice seeds are planted around this time so that the seedlings can be transplanted immediately after the real monsoon rain begins. Thus, the association of the Ganga's story with this particular season of the Indic calendar clearly indicates that the legend of Bhagiratha and the Ganga's descent is actually a mythological interpretation of the annual summer drought followed by the monsoon rains. This observation becomes more meaningful if we note the fact that the author of the *Natyashastra* refers to the *makara* not as *makara* but as *dhara*, rain shower. The word *dhara*, as we mentioned earlier, is also a Nepali synonym for the *hitimanga*. Evidently, the *makara* spout actually represents the phenomenon of monsoon rain, which in turn, in Bhagiratha's story, is the descent of the river goddess Ganga.

The rare Licchavi-period statue of Bhagiratha below the *hitimanga* is important for two different reasons. On one hand, it tells us that the ancient people of the Kathmandu valley were familiar with the belief that Ganga's descent signifies early monsoon rain, the *makara* fountain being the artistic expression of the notion. On the other hand, the greater popularity of the custom of placing images of *yakshas*, rather than of Bhagiratha, under the spout of fountains during the early and transitional period clearly indicates that although the *makara* fountain symbolized the monsoon rain it was not then exclusively identified with Ganga. This is interesting because in the history of South Asian art, the association of Ganga with the *makara* was fixed only after the 2nd or 3rd century CE. Before that, the *makara* was represented in Indic art as the animal-vehicle of the goddess Shri/Lakshmi, representing rain-river and agrarian prosperity, discussed in detail in Chapter 9.

In the early history of the Indic civilization, the Sarasvati river played a much more important role than the Ganga. Although the Sarasvati gradually dried out and is now almost nonexistent, we know from textual evidence that the earlier civilizations of the



subcontinent flourished on the banks of this river before the people of the region moved to the Gangetic valley. Even when the initial part of the *Mahabharata* was composed, the centre of activity of the epic was Asandivat, the Vedic capital city in Madhyadesha through which flowed the Sarasvati river. Originally, the Sarasvati was known to the local people of the Punjab as Vaishambalya or Vaishamphalya.²⁴ The Vedic people, who settled on the banks of the river, preferred to call it Sarasvati, perhaps nostalgically recalling the river Harahvati of their earlier homeland in modern-day Afghanistan. The significance of the original legends of the Harahvati and Sarasvati must have been very different, because the Sarasvati river, just like the Ganga, is mythically associated with the monsoon flood, which was unknown in Afghanistan. As we mentioned in Chapter 5, Vedic literature such as the *Jaiminiya Brahmana* and *Taittiriya Brahmana* describe how the Sarasvati river descends to the earth on the day of the summer solstice together with the monsoon rains and then enters the nether world as it disappears in a place called Vinashana (literally, passing out of existence) located in the sands of the Thar desert. But this mysterious river reappears in a place called Chamasodbheda, “the sudden appearance of the *chamasa*”, whose exact location is unknown, but somewhere near Gujarat. *Chamasa* is the Sanskrit word for a vessel; but it also means Ursa Major or the Big Dipper, which is believed to be the celestial source of the Sarasvati river. An epic version of this Vedic story is available in the *Mahabharata*, which might have partially

contributed to keeping the old story alive in later periods.

The subterranean construction of the water channels and the iconographic elements of *yaksha* images placed below the fountains and sometimes flanked by directional elephants (figure 7.15) certainly bear some similarities with the legend of the celestial river that descended from heaven to the earth and eventually entered the nether world. As we know from numerous artistic representations, the *yakshas* reside in the nether world and carry the burden of the land above, including the mountains. The same concept is also depicted in the art of the Newar fountain through the body posture of the Atlas-like *yakshas* lifting the earth/mountains.

A 7th-century Licchavi inscription refers to a royal donation of a fountain to a Buddhist monastery.²⁵ In the inscription the fountain is compared with the mysterious river that disappears from the surface of the earth to enter the nether world (*patala*) and further on reappears at the surface. This description tallies with the story of the Sarasvati river; however the inscription is partially missing and a direct reference to the river cannot be found. Further, the well-known *Gopalarajavamshavali*, compiled in the 14th century, associates the water fountains of the Kathmandu valley not with the celebrated Ganga river, but with the mythical river Val Val (*Valavala nadi*, *Valavala devi*, *Valavala kha*).²⁶ This proper name of the river elucidates the significance of the Newar fountain. The word *val val* derives from a Vedic (actually pre-Vedic) onomatopoeic word *bal bal* indicating the torrential rain, the flow of a stream, and the birth of a child. Apparently, this is a pre-Vedic word because it is always used

7.12

Hitimanga, Mangal Bazaar, Patan. Photograph: author.



7.13

Yakshas below the Kohiti hitimanga, Kathmandu, c. 7th century CE. Photograph: author.



7.14
Bhagiratha, Kanga Ajima shrine, Kathmandu, c. 7th century CE. From Mary Slusser, *Nepal Mandala*, 2 vols. (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1982).

with *iti* ("thus", or "so-called") implying that the quotation is from a non-Vedic aboriginal language.²⁷ Since the concept associated with the word is important for our investigation, I will quote the related Vedic paragraphs in translation:

May the rain fall down with the sound of *bal*. (*Atharvaveda* 18.2.22)

I breach your pudenda, womb, *gavini*[], the mother, the son, the embryo, and the placenta; let the baby be out of you sounding like *bal*. (*Taittiriya Brahmana* 3.3.10.1–2)

Therefore, the waters flow down with the sound of "*bal bal bal*". (*Jaiminiya Brahmana* 3.360)

These statements correlate with the belief that the shower of rain is actually the birth of a divine child. According to Vedic literature, clouds are rivers, and they carry a child as they descend to the earth. This concept is indeed still alive in the Kathmandu valley. The Newars of Deopatan celebrate the descent of the trifurcated rain river Trishula (Trishula Jatra) on a particular day of the monsoon called

Bhal Bhal (or Bal Bal Ashtami), when they carry in a procession eight- or nine-year-old boys and girls, lying flat on top of trident-like poles of cosmic significance. The boys and girls are regarded as *kumaras* and *kumaris*; hence, they are chosen on the day of Sithinakha, "the festival of Shashthi", when the birthday of the rain child Kumara is celebrated throughout the valley. The season of planting rice seeds in the valley begins with this celebration and the transplanting of rice seedlings takes place on the day of Bhal Bhal (the eighth day of the dark half of Ashadha, June/July) when torrential monsoon rain is expected. Readers will find more about the significance of the Sithi and the Bhal Bhal festivals in Chapter 8.

Early Vedic texts also tell us that the rivers of the Punjab, the Sarasvati being the most important of them, are the earthly representations of multiple cloud-rivers. The name Punjab itself derives from Sanskrit *panchapas* (*pancha-apas*). The second word *apas* (in plural) denotes waters, clouds, and rivers at once. Thus, in Vedic Sanskrit *apas* stand for both the celestial and terrestrial



7.15
Yaksha flanked by elephants, below the *thusa-hiti*, Sundari Chok, Patan. Photograph: author.



rivers, which were believed to be the mothers of the rain-child, *hiranyagarbha*, "golden fetus/germ" (see Chapter 1). More important, the onomatopoeic word *bal* is also associated with the earlier name of the Sarasvati river. Philological investigations have convincingly reconstructed the ancient non-Sanskritic names for the Sarasvati – *Vaishambalya* or *Vaishamphalya* – as *Vishambal* or *Vishambhal*.²⁸ Note that the reconstructed names of the river end with *bal* or *bhal*.

Almost certainly, this non-Sanskritic name is also related to the Vedic story that the Sarasvati is not a river but a giant tree symbolizing the cosmic pillar, thus the river was designated in early literature as *plaksha prasaravana*, the torrential descent of the *plaksha* tree (*Ficus infectoria*). Since the word *bal* or *bhal* is onomatopoeic for waterfall, we think that *Vishambal* is actually a synonym for *plaksha prasaravana*.

The significance of the Sarasvati river survived in the legends and rituals of the post-Vedic period. In the *Mahabharata*, the Yamuna is identified with the Sarasvati. In Nepal the Sarasvati was identified with the Trishula Gandaki, which was known to the Newars of the valley as *Sihluti*, "Tree Fountain".²⁹ Like the Vedic people, even today the Newars enthusiastically participate in the

long journey that leads to the source of the river in the Himalaya, at the lake known in Nepali as *Gosainkunda*. In both Vedic literature and Newar legends, multiple lakes are described as situated at the source of rivers.³⁰ Their descent from the celestial region was visualized as branches of the riverine tree. In the story of the Sarasvati or *plaksha prasaravana*, the river-tree is said to have two branches that hold the solar disc, but in the case of *Sihluti*, as we know from the artistic representation of the river in a Philadelphia Museum of Art scroll painting, it has three forks emerging directly from a rain cloud (figures 7.16 and 7.17). An inscription near the scene identifies the forks as *trishura dhara* (Sanskrit *trishula dhara*, a three-forked water fountain).³¹ This epigraphic and visual evidence explains how the river became known as *Trishula Gandaki* as it was visualized as a rain-river cascading from the atmosphere in three forks. The rain-river is not a river but a tree or a tree-fountain (*Sihluti*). Therefore, the forks of the atmospheric river actually represent triple branches of the riverine tree. Shaivites, however, identified the forks as a trident; hence, they Sanskritized the original Newari name *Sihluti* as *Shivalhuti*, Shiva's fountain. With this Shaivite interpretation, within the last 1,400 years the story of the lake developed, in which Nilakantha Shiva reclines like *Vishnu*.

7.16

Pilgrimage to *Sihluti* (*Gosainkunda*), Nepal, probably *Bhaktapur*, c. 1775. Colours on cloth; 83.4 x 435.6 cm. Philadelphia Museum of Art, Stella Kramrisch Fund, 2007-7-3. Photograph courtesy Philadelphia Museum of Art.



The artistic and anthropologic aspects of Nilakantha Shiva and reclining Vishnu have been a subject of discussion for at least three decades,³² before the Philadelphia Museum painting became available to us. An interesting point about reclining deities related to the symbolic significance of Sihluti concerns a monumental image of an enigmatic deity reclining in the water of a small pond located in a place called Hluti at the northwest corner of the Kathmandu valley. This place is believed to be one of the two local substitutes in the valley of the Himalayan natural lake of Sihluti (the other substitute being the fountain and pond in the vicinity of the Kumbheshvara temple in Patan). In reality, there is no image in the Himalayan lake, but the Hindu and Buddhist devotees of Nepal, depending on their religious belief, visualize an image of Shiva – or more recently Bhagavan Buddha – peacefully reclining there. The recumbent image at Hluti is worshipped as a representation of the Hindu or Buddhist deity. Traditionally, this image is, however, known as Valaju or Balaju. The people of the valley including the Newars, if they are inclined to Sanskritization, prefer to call the deity not Vahlaju, Valaju, or Balaju, but Bala Nilakantha, the Child Nilakantha. They explain that the Balaju image is secondary to Budha Nilakantha, Old Nilakantha, located

at the northern border of the valley in a place called Bhuijasi in Newari. The identity of these two recumbent images as Nilakantha is indeed problematic because iconographically the so-called Bala Nilakantha can be identified as Harihara,³³ whereas Budha Nilakantha is Jalashayana Narayana.³⁴

We may find out how the confusion began if we understand the real meaning of the Newari word Valaju or Balaju and its association with the ancient story of the gestation of water. The iconography of reclining Vishnu is related to the characteristic of a foetus floating in water, its life sustained by an umbilical cord. In Sanskrit a foetus is known as *uttanashaya*, “reclining supine”, and the umbilical cord is called *nala*, which also means the stem of a lotus. In the iconography of recumbent Vishnu, the lotus stem that emerges from the navel actually represents both the stem and the umbilical cord. Thus, Jalashayana Vishnu is described in Sanskrit texts as *garbhodakashayin*, “reclining in amniotic water [of the cosmos]”. This is a Puranic expression based on the pre-Vedic view that creation begins with the germination of a golden foetus (*hiranyagarbha*) in the cloud-river or cloud-ocean (*apas*).

The original Newari legend of Balaju or Valaju is related to a similar ancient concept, prevalent before the Hindu iconography of



Jalashayana Narayana was fixed. The ancient Newari synonym for the foetus, seed, and grain is *vahla*, also spelt as *vala*, *bala*, or *bahra*, which we know from several sources. First, the Newar ritual of dispersing the seeds on the day of Bala Chahre (the 14th day of the dark half of Margashirsha) is called *balagu* or *vahlagu vanegu*. According to astrologers responsible for making the traditional Newar calendar, the Sanskrit translation of *bala* or *vahla* is *bija*, or seed; hence, they know the ritual of *balagu vanegu* alternatively as dispersing *shatabija*, hundred seeds. Second, planting seedlings at the beginning of the monsoon is called *vahlajya* or *bolajya*, “seed job”, in Newari. It is known to Nepali-speaking people as *ropaim* (monsoonal) planting. Third, the Newari Buddhist ritual of giving alms of grains is called *baram* or *bahram chuigu*, giving grain/seeds, which is associated with the *ihī* or *yihi*, a ceremony in which adolescent Newar girls are married to a divine groom symbolized by the wood apple or ber fruit, *Aegle marmelos*. (*Bahram chuigu* is different from *bahre chuigu*, “converting into the honorable (Buddhist) monk Vandya”.) Fourth, the “womb or seed vessel” used in the Newar religious rite is known as *vahla bhyaga* (Sanskrit *garbhapatra*).³⁵ Thus I believe that originally Balaju was the god of seed/foetus.

The history of the Sanskritization of the culture of the Kathmandu valley is at least as old as the Licchavi period. The original story

of Balaju was Sanskritized already by the 7th century CE or perhaps even earlier. Apparently, the divine seed/foetus was identified then sometimes as a reclining Vishnu, at other times as a deity who holds the attributes of both Vishnu and Shiva. We do not find any textual references to such a composite Hindu deity shown reclining in water. But we know from Amshuvarman's inscription that before Vishnugupta (c. 633–641) established the reclining image of Vishnu currently known as Budha Nilakantha there was already a reclining image of a deity, not necessarily a recumbent Vishnu. The exact word used in the inscription of Amshuvarman for the reclining image is *bhumbhukkikajalashayana*, “recumbent in the water of *bhumbhukkika*”.³⁶ Apparently, *bhumbhukkika* is a Sanskritized onomatopoeic word for the sound of water, hence for the water tank as well; whereas the Sanskrit word *jalashayana* means “reclining in water”. Since the word that indicates Vishnu is completely lacking, it may well be that the recumbent image was not an image of Vishnu but a small image representing a tutelary deity of Newar farmers. Only after it was newly identified as reclining Vishnu, did the Licchavi king Vishnugupta replace it with the monumental image of Jalashayana Narayana. The prominent iconographic feature of the god, namely reclining in water, derives from the belief that he remains dormant for three or four rainy months in the womb of the cosmic water, which is the seasonal rain of the monsoon. This is the time the Newar farmers observe the rite *vahla* (or *wahlah*) *chvanegu*, “staying [like] a foetus”. The link between the ritual concept related to the foetus and Vishnu's iconography is the psychological impact of the monsoon itself. Constant torrential rain leading to confinement within a limited space makes human beings feel that they are actually floating or drowning in the water of the cosmic womb.³⁷ Thus, the concept of a divine child being born in water is still discernible today in the work of traditional Newar artists. In Kirtipur there is an unpretentious open shrine sheltering a 20th-century stone image of

7.17
Pilgrimage to Sihluti
(Gosainkunda), detail of figure
7.16 showing *trishula dhara*,
the Trishula descending from
a rain cloud in three streams.
Photograph: author.

a mother goddess, Dharati Mata, giving birth to a child (figure 7.18). The figure of the child is shown almost fully emerged from the womb, and both child and mother are depicted reclining on the surface of water delineated with semicircular ripples.³⁸

The image of reclining Vishnu as a cosmic child is also related to the 2nd or 3rd century CE stone image of the mother goddess near the Balaju pond in Hluti.³⁹ She sits majestically on a low bench with both legs pendant (*pralambapadasana*) and protectively holds a baby in her lap. She is worshipped currently as Hluti Ajima Dya, Divine Grandmother of Hluti. Statements found in *Shashthikalpa*, "Shashthi Rituals", a chapter of a *Grihyasutra* text,⁴⁰ composed around the 3rd century BCE, Bana's 7th century CE work, *Kadambari*, and the Newari birth ritual associated with Shashthi inform us that very likely she is Shashthi, the goddess representing both the sixth day after the birth of a human child as well as the sixth day of rain when the monsoon officially begins. This is the day when Newars celebrate the birthday of the rain child Kumara as Sithinakha, "the festival of the sixth day", an ancient custom. In the *Grihyasutra* the goddess Shashthi is identified with Shri/Lakshmi, the goddess of monsoonal phenomena such as rain, mud, lotus, fertility, and agrarian prosperity (see Chapter 9), whereas in *Kadambari* the deity with the same name is described as a mother goddess worshipped after the delivery of a child. The Hadigaun inscription of Amshuvarman refers to one of her shrines as Shashthidevakula, and the

inscription is issued on the sixth-day celebration of Kumara's birth. Even now during the sixth-day birth ritual, Newars identify a midwife as the mother goddess; hence, they know her as Aji, grandmother. On the sixth day after the birth of a child, she cuts the baby's umbilical cord and purifies the delivery room literally as well as ritually. Though she belongs to a "low" caste, throughout the ritual of the morning, she is treated with great respect as it is believed that she represents Ajima Dya, and if she is not pleased, the baby might not survive. Evidently, the goddess Ajima is still associated with the Sashthi ritual of Newars.

Furthermore, the umbilical cord is thrown in a designated place called *chvasa*. Originally this area was always located outside the residential area where garbage was discarded. The significance of such a place to the agricultural society of Newars is twofold. First, the debris is collected biannually to use in the farm as fertilizing manure before the vernal and monsoonal planting begins. Second, the mother goddess Chvasa Ajima resides there in an invisible form. When babies are sick, the mother goddess receives offerings of fruits and rice coloured with yellow pigment – preferably juice extracted from *haridra*, the turmeric plant. She is also the goddess of the umbilical cord and presides over the sixth day when the cord is removed. Such complex association of the goddess with human and agricultural fertility is crucial to understand why in Nepal and Tibet she is also known as Shridevi or goddess of wealth in Sanskrit, and Palden Hlamo in Tibetan. Certainly, it does appear very strange to us that the goddess of umbilical cords who resides in debris is also the deity of prosperity, but this has to be an ancient belief of agrarian people. Already in the *Grihyasutra*, the mother goddess Shashthi is identified with the goddess of wealth, Shri/Lakshmi who is described there as *karishini*, rich in manure.

Stylistically, the image of Hluti Ajima is about four centuries older than the recumbent image of Balaju; this indicates that the pond was an important religious place before the



7.18

Mother goddess giving birth to a child, both mother and child floating on water, Kirtipur, Kathmandu valley, 20th century. Photograph: author.

recumbent deity was consecrated there. The existence of the mother goddess's image in Hluti, however, does not necessarily contradict the supposition that the site is the substitute for the remote Himalayan Sihluti. Rather it supports this assertion because the significance of Hluti originates from the natural water found there. This water became associated not only with the legend of Sihluti but also with the divine foetus Balaju because the mother goddess vouchsafes and protects both children and harvest. Such a concept must have been popular all over South Asia and we find a reflection of it even in Southeast Asia. According to the people of Bali, Gangadevi represents the rice after transplantation; Shridevi is the cut rice that is not yet threshed; whereas Umadevi and Girinatha are the holy names of the rice-seed and the young rice plant respectively.⁴¹ When we compare this statement (namely the relation between mother goddess and rice) with the Newar celebration of the rain child Kumara's birth as the beginning of early monsoon rain, the identification of the mother goddess with Shashthi, the goddess representing the sixth day of Jyeshtha, becomes meaningful.

More recently, the Himalayan lake of Sihluti became affiliated with the Gosain, a medieval-period religious sect; hence, it is now called Gosainkunda. As a result the original significance of the river is completely forgotten. However, the Newars are still fascinated with the story of the river and lake, perhaps because they originally migrated from Nuwakot or Nevakota to the Kathmandu valley. Although the river does not enter the valley, traditionally the Newars believed that the source of the water in the valley is the Trishula Gandaki. They believed that ducks lost in the small pond and fountain at Patan Kumbheshvara will be found in the lake of Gosainkunda.⁴² Another legend goes as follows: "Long ago, a pilgrim while bathing in *Gosainkunda* dropped his brass water pot and it sank out of sight. Sometime later, it appeared in Kumbheshvara pond in Patan. People believe the vessel made its way from the mountain lake through some

subterranean river into Kumbheshvara pond".⁴³

This Newar legend distantly echoes the story of Ursa Major, known in Vedic literature as the dipper or *chamasa*, and the reappearance of the subterranean river Sarasvati at Chamasodbheda, mentioned above. The Kumbheshvara pond, in a sense, is a Nepali version of the important site of Chamasodbheda. This seems to be the reason why the god residing in a nearby temple was named Kumbheshvara, Lord of the *kumbha*.

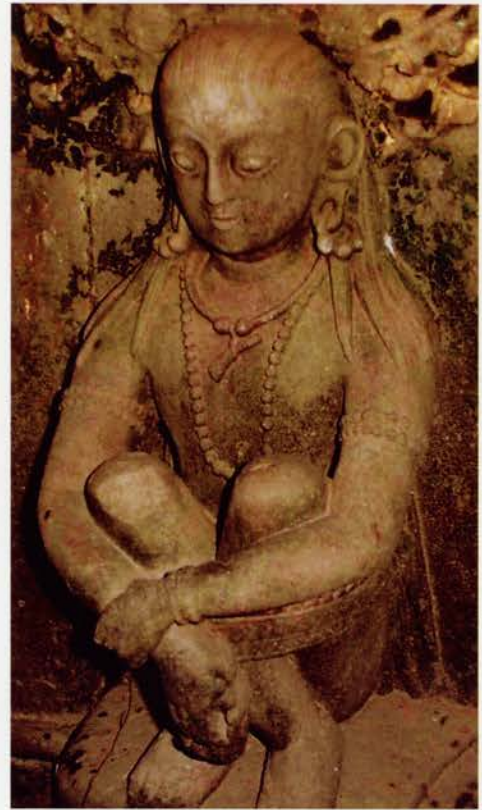
The Sihluti river descends to earth from heaven on Shravana Shukla Purnima, which

7.19 and 7.20

Bhagiratha flanked by *makaras* and *jalamanusas* above and below the *jahrum*, Taumadhi Tol, Bhaktapur, 18th century. Photographs: author.



is considered to be the ideal day for taking a bath in Gosainkunda. On the same day the Newars of the valley block the drainage system of the fountain of Kumbheshvara in Patan. As a result the sunken water fountain appears as if flooded by monsoon rain, and the Newars take a ritual bath in the water every year at this time. Although the tank and fountain are now associated with a Shiva temple, this particular time of the year corresponds with the summer solstice when Sarasvati falls from the heavens, as the snow of the Himalaya starts melting and the monsoon arrives (see Chapter 5). This explains why in the Philadelphia Museum of Art scroll painting the Trishula Gandaki is shown descending from a cloud (figures 7.16 and 7.17). This cloud-river actually enters the Kathmandu valley as the monsoon river Bhal Bhal. This view is based on three different sources. First, the *Gopalarajavamshavali* constantly associates the Val Val river with water fountains. Second, the fountains symbolize the rain-river, the three spouts of the Kumbheshvara fountain being the architectural representation of the scene of atmospheric showers, identified in the Philadelphia Museum painting as *trishura dhara*, three-forked water fountain. Third, the Deopatan festival celebrated on the day of Bhal Bhal is designated as Trishula Jatra (the festival of the trident or the Trishula river). Thus, we can see how the cloud-river turns into the local river Tekhu (Vagmati, Sanskrit Vanmati). Compare the Sarasvati river's identity with *vak*, sound (which is *bhal bhal*). The river disappears from the Kathmandu valley at a place called Koina or Koinla, at the southern border of the valley. Koina is a compound word consisting of *ko* (downward) and *ina* (disappearance). The latter is apparently the Newari version of Vinashana, the name of the location where the Sarasvati river disappears. The Sanskrit *vi* regularly turns into *i* in Newari; for instance Vinayaka deva became Inay dya in Newari. Likewise, *itan* or *ilan* is the Newari word for Sanskrit *vitana*. Thus, it is reasonable to believe that Newari *ina* or *inla* is cognate to Vinashana in Sanskrit. Only after the real significance of the location



was forgotten did the Newars associate the place with Vinayaka or Ganesha and identify a stone with the deity.

Irrespective of the monsoon river's identity with any particular river, the water fountains of the valley are indeed admirable artistic representations of the view of monsoon rain as the descent of the celestial river. For many centuries, this view remained the common property of Newars. A Newar artist responsible for the 18th-century scroll painting, narrating the story of the local rain-god Bungadya and the severe drought caused by the terrible battle between two monarchs, symbolically represents the drought by depicting a man begging for water in front of a dry *makara* fountain. In the same painting, the artist depicts a scene of lovemaking and huge volumes of water emanating from a fountain – symbolically connecting the phenomena of rain and happy times.⁴⁴ This piece of visual evidence is valuable because it not only clarifies the symbolism of the *makara* fountain but also helps answer the

7.21
Bhagiratha below the
hitimanga, Hanumandhoka
palace, Kathmandu, 17th
century. Photograph: Gudrun
Bühnemann.

question of why South Asian art repeatedly shows sexuality on the walls of temples.

After Ganga was identified with the water fountain in the late medieval period, not only the fountain but also the flow of water from a *jahrum* (waterspout; Sanskrit *jaladroni*) was considered Ganga's descent. Now every drop of water is Ganga-jala. Therefore in an example of *jahrum* in Bhaktapur, Bhagiratha, identified by the conchshell that he is blowing, is depicted immediately above and below the spout (figures 7.19 and 7.20), flanked by rows of mythical creatures and objects, such as *makara*, *jalamanusha*, and conch. All these creatures and the conchshell appear on the ceiling paintings of Ajanta and also at Nako in Kinnaur.

The popularity of Bhagiratha's image in the medieval period, however, did not replace the *yaksha* images. Rather, they continued to survive side by side. For instance, the Malla king of Patan, Siddhinarasimha (ruled c. 1619–61) embellished his golden fountain with an image of *yaksha* flanked by two *diggajas*, elephants of the quarters (see figure 7.15); whereas his contemporary, the Malla king of Kathmandu, Pratapamalla (ruled c. 1641–74), chose to place Bhagiratha's statue below his palace fountain (figure 7.21). In fact this statue is one of the most impressive examples of Malla-period stone sculpture. The unknown artist responsible for this work must have been highly praised by the king and his people for creating such a well-proportioned, almost life-size statue of Bhagiratha, peacefully seated in yogic posture under the deep shadow of the waterspout.

Creatures of the Rain-Rivers

According to the stories of the rain-rivers, both aquatic creatures and domesticated animals descend from heaven together with rain. Such stories are still alive in most of South Asia. In Nepal, for instance, there is an image of a fish carved on a rectangular stone paving about a metre wide, on the ground almost in the middle of Asan Tol, a popular marketplace situated in the northeast section of old Kathmandu city. Local people tell us that this fish descended



from the atmosphere together with torrential rain, which terminated a long-lasting drought. Likewise, the elders of Patan explain that the golden fountain in Sundari Chok is called *thusa-hiti*, calf fountain, because the golden calf emerging from the *makara* of the fountain represents a real calf which rained down from the sky at the location where we now have the *hitimanga*. The repousse image of the golden calf of *thusa-hiti* is almost gone (figure 7.22); but the Newari name of the fountain and representations of the calf or bull in other examples of fountains (see figures 7.9, 7.11, and 7.23) help us to discern the original existence of a calf at the end of the metal spout at the *thusa-hiti*.

In South Asia the bull is associated with atmospheric water, not because the Vedic people believed that the father sky is a bull, which impregnates the mother earth with its rain/seed, but because the healthy growth of cattle is among the monsoonal phenomena of the subcontinent. During a severe drought the herds of cattle and other domesticated animals dwindle. This situation changes dramatically soon after the monsoon arrives when, due to the availability of nutritious vegetation, the animals thrive. The people of South Asia must have experienced this phenomenon many times in the long history of the subcontinent. This could have led them to believe that domesticated

7.22
Thusa-hiti (detail from
7.15), Sundari Chok, Patan.
Photograph: author.

animals descend to the earth with torrential rain. We find such a belief clearly recorded in Vedic texts: in the following hymns of the *Rigveda*, for instance, Pavamana Soma, who is regarded as the great god presiding over the ritually extracted *soma* juice, symbolizing rain, was expected to bring not only rain but also livestock:

O Soma, make the rain descend from heaven. (9.39.2)

Bring the rain/seed that provides us with the *praja* [baby animals and offspring]. (9.60.4)

You are the life, give us life. (9.67.8)

Pour us [the rain] that brings prosperity, gold, stallions, cattle, grains, and heroic strength. (9.69.8)

[O Soma,] provide us with hundreds of horses, thousands of livestock (*pashu*) and gold. (9.72.9)

O Soma, flow with that of your torrential rain shower (*dhara*) with which cows came along here. (9.49.2)

Compare these Rigvedic expressions with the artistic representations of horses, goats, and cows on the spouts of the golden fountains of Bhaktapur and Kathmandu, and the stone fountain of Changu (see figures 7.9–7.11). Despite the huge time difference between them, the Rigvedic statements and Newar artistic expressions are both based on the same concept – that animals descend from the heavens together with torrential rain. In particular, the repeated depiction of the calf emerging from the *dhara/makara* of Newar fountains (see figures 7.9, 7.11, and 7.23) clearly indicates the prevalence of the concept. Certainly, such similarities between Newar art and Vedic verses cannot be the result of the popularity of Vedic concepts in medieval Nepal; rather they exemplify the continuity of monsoonal culture, renewed every year as the dry summer season turns into the rainy season. It is this enduring link that provides us with the logic behind the undoubted usefulness of Vedic literature for explaining South Asian art of a much later period.

In addition to Rigvedic expressions, we have an interesting statement from the *Baudhayana Grihyasutra*, a later Vedic text, which throws more light on our study of Newar fountains. I quote the related passage in translation:

This is a *purta* (wish-fulfilling) ritual associated with the denizens (*yaksha* and *yakshi*) of the bridge, river, cavity of ground, tank, lotus pond, pool, well, shrine and temple, and also with perennial plants and trees. An *adhvaryu* (officiating priest), desirous of prosperity, should perform the ritual at night during or at the end of the summer solstice or on the auspicious conjunction of the moon with the lunar mansion. He should prepare the objects required for the *yajna* ritual: golden images of snakes, *shimshumara*, turtle, *makara*, crab, silver images of fish and frogs, [various types of lotuses such as] *kamala*, *kuvalaya*, *kumuda*, *utpala*, *kahlara*, the [miniature] statues of the denizens of shrines and temples, exactly as they appear in their representations (*akriti*) and the fruits of perennial plants and trees.... Then on the bank of a pond, the *adhvaryu* should erect...a three-cubit-tall sacrificial post (*yupa*) made of *khadira* (*Acacia catechu*) or *palasha* (*Butea monosperma*) tree.... He should wrap the post in cloth and fasten the [golden and silver] images on [the post]. (4.4.1–2)

The ritual was accompanied by the chanting of various Vedic mantras associated with rain and waters, because the main purpose of the ritual erection of the sacrificial post was to obtain rainwater for agrarian prosperity. At first glance, such ritual association of the sacrificial post with the phenomenon of rain may appear surprising. But here we should be aware that symbolically the post represents the axis mundi described in the *Atharvaveda* as *skambha*.⁴⁵ The cosmic pillar originally symbolized solar light, but in India, as we know from textual sources, the solar symbolism was drastically modified and the pillar then reinterpreted as the



riverine tree Sarasvati that holds the solar disc between its two branches (see Chapter 5). It is this rain-river that annually descends from the heavens when the monsoon arrives. Once we are familiar with this notion of the monsoon culture of South Asia, we can see that the significance of the aquatic creatures associated with the ritual of the cosmic pole may not differ much from the symbolism of the same creatures depicted on the Newar *hitimangas*. In a sense, if the pillar represents the rain-river vertically, the *hitimanga* does so horizontally.

In Nepal it was customary to erect a stone *yupa* (Vedic sacrificial post) near the fountain. At the sunken fountain of the Bhaktapur palace, the *yupa* was erected above the fountain on the terrace to the right of the spout, whereas at Manga Hiti, Patan (figure 7.23) it was erected between two waterspouts in a sunken area. Obviously, the ancient Newars believed the *yupa* to be an important feature of a water fountain. This concept seems to be the origin of the Nagaya Pukhu, Serpent's Tank, where we see a pillar designed like the erect body of a serpent in the middle of the water. In Bhaktapur palace such a tank is part of the royal fountain (see figure 7.2). In Kathmandu too, Pratapamalla built a serpent's tank and fountain as a single entity. Because in the Manga Hiti the pillar is erected in a sunken area, which gets inundated easily, one can surmise that after the sunken area turned into a tank, the *yupa* or *yahsim* became the serpent's erect body. Support for this view derives from the festival and history associated with Tava Pukhu, Large Pond, currently known as Siddhapukhu in Bhaktapur. Originally, this pond was adorned with the serpentine pillar. In 1663 Pratapamalla

plundered the pillar and used it to decorate his palace in Kathmandu, erecting it in the palatial pond mentioned above. The Tava Pukhu of Bhaktapur is currently devoid of any such pillar, but on the full-moon day of Bhadra, which is an important day of the week-long autumnal *yupa/yahsim* festival, Newars of the valley still gather around the Tava Pukhu tank to celebrate the important day, which is marked in the Nepali calendar as Siddhapukhu or Siddhapokhari Mela. Thus, it becomes evident that the serpentine pillar is actually a *yupa/yahsim*, though it did not replace the traditional way of erecting the *yupa*. In Bhaktapur we see the survival of the *yupa* and serpent's tank side by side. The aquatic creatures are associated with both the Vedic *yupa* and the Newar fountain because they symbolize the rain-river.

Denizens of the Cloud-Lakes: Same Creatures, Same Meaning

The observation above on the creatures of the rain-river prods us to expand the horizon of our study beyond Nepal, because most of the creatures that we see on the spouts of the Newar fountains appear throughout the history of Indic art. The prime examples are the Ajanta ceiling paintings. The concept of atmospheric gestation, mentioned earlier, is expressed on the Ajanta ceiling depicting *makara*, elephants, fish, bull, turtle, water buffaloes, and lotuses emerging from a so-called foliage motif, but described in a Sanskrit text as *meghapatra*, cloud-foliage motif. The Newars were surely familiar with this concept, as the *meghapatra* motif is known to them as *lapva*, amniotic water, the fluid which surrounds the foetus in the womb. Second, the clouds are the aerial lake of Kuvera, and all the creatures depicted on the ceiling are the denizens of the lake and neighbouring regions (see Chapter 6). The rain-rivers flow down out of this atmospheric lake.

Thus, almost all the objects including the conchshell (see figure 7.10) rendered on the spout of the Newar fountain also appear in the Ajanta ceiling paintings. The representation of *jalamanusha* is difficult to find, but at least one

7.23

Water spouts at Manga Hiti, Patan. Photograph courtesy Jwari Ratna Bajracharya.

7.24

Ceiling painting in a temple at Nako, Kinnaur, c. 11th century CE. Photograph courtesy Deborah E. Klimburg-Salter.



7.25

Fishtailed elephant, Bharhut, c. 2nd century BCE. Photograph courtesy American Institute of Indian Studies (AIIS), Gurgaon.



7.26

Fishtailed Bull, Bharhut, c. 2nd century BCE. Photograph courtesy American Institute of Indian Studies (AIIS), Gurgaon.



example is available to us on the ceiling of cave 1. If we look for such images in ceiling paintings of later periods, we find several of them without much difficulty. A ceiling painting from Nako, Kinnaur, depicting various creatures (figure 7.24) is a good example. In the Indian artistic tradition, the image of *jalamanusha* is always identified as a *kinnara*. The Newar artists of the valley were familiar with this Indian designation, but they insisted on calling it *jalamanusha*, aquatic human figure. The literal meaning of the word indicates that it is the original designation, because its association with water explains why it is depicted not only on the ceilings but also on waterspouts together with other aquatic creatures. The former represents a cloud-lake, whereas the waterspout is the rain-river descending from the same atmospheric lake.

The symbolic creatures that we see on Newar *hitimangas* and Ajanta ceiling paintings also appear on the shafts of the uprights of the stone railings or *vedikas* of the ancient stupas at Bharhut, Bodhgaya, and Sanchi. They are depicted within the medallions and half-medallions carved on the stone railings. The list of the creatures shown there includes aquatic, semiaquatic, mythical, and domesticated

animals – *makara*, fish, elephant, cow, and horse (figures 7.25 and 7.26). Most of these creatures and varieties of lotuses carved on the *vedikas* correlate with the creatures and lotuses placed on the *yupa* for the Purta ritual mentioned in the *Baudhayana Grihyasutra* (4.4.1–2).

The creatures carved on the stone railings of Bharhut and other ancient sites have fishtails which I think is actually an iconographic device used by ancient artists to convey the idea that the creatures are the denizens of celestial lakes, the rain-clouds. The fishtail motif was replaced around the 3rd century CE by the cloud-foilage motif. For instance, before the 3rd century the *makara* is invariably shown with fishtail (figure 7.27), and in later examples with the cloud-foilage motif (figure 7.28).

Further evidence for the symbolic significance of the animals comes from the representation of various creatures perched on the lotus. The Bharhut and Sanchi railings, for example, show not only birds but also elephants, stallions, and human beings, standing comfortably but impossibly on a lotus leaf or flower (figures 7.29–7.32). Such supernatural scenes remind us of the description of the aerial

7.27

Fishtailed *makara*, Bharhut, c. 2nd century BCE. Photograph courtesy American Institute of Indian Studies (AIIS), Gurgaon.



7.28

Makara with *meghapatra* motif, Ajanta cave 19, c. 5th century CE. Photograph: author.





7.29–7.32
Pokkharasataka motifs with
elephants, horses, female
figures, and birds standing
on lotuses, Bharhut, c. 2nd
century BCE. Photographs
courtesy American Institute
of Indian Studies (AIIS),
Gurgaon.



lake where one can expect to see "(creatures) perched on the lotuses", known in Pali literature as *pokkharasatakas* (see Chapter 6). Apparently, stories of such creatures were widely prevalent in ancient India. *Pushkarasada*, the Sanskrit version of *pokkharasataka*, was a popular personal name in Vedic literature. In the *Taittiriya Samhita* (4.5.13) and other Vedic texts, *pushkarasada* is listed as a creature to be sacrificed in the *ashvamedha yajna* or horse sacrifice. Thus *pushkarasada* could be the name of a real creature; however, the list includes creatures with mythical associations such as *chaturaksha*, a four-eyed dog. According to Vedic legend Yama, the god of death, has two ferocious dogs, described in *Rigveda* 10.14.10–11 as *chaturaksha*. Therefore while it is highly possible that *pushkarasada* is a real creature, it received its interesting name because of its association with a myth, in which not only birds but also huge creatures like elephants are able to stand on lotus flowers and leaves.

The iconography of Gajalakshmi, where we see not only the goddess but also the elephants

standing on huge lotuses, is directly associated with the story of the celestial and terrestrial lakes. This view is further evidenced by two different points: first by the identification of the elephants with rain clouds as Coomaraswamy convincingly explained many decades ago;⁴⁶ second by the presence, in an early sculpture representing Gajalakshmi, of two human figures who can be identified as *dandamanavakas* because lotus vines grow from their navels (see Chapter 6). On top of these lotus vines stand the elephants pouring water on the head of Lakshmi (see figure 6.24). According to the *Dighanikaya* both *pokkharasataka* and *dandamanavaka* are denizens of the cloud-lake Dharani. Thus one can surmise that the iconography of Gajalakshmi is closely related to the mythical lake.

An interesting example of the *pushkarasada* motif is a relief on the Bodhgaya railing where the cloud-foliage motif is used meaningfully, depicting the atmospheric lake inhabited by a cloud-bird perched on a giant cloud-lotus (figure 7.33). Thus, both the fishtailed creatures and the mythical figures standing on the lotus flowers and leaves suggest that the plants and creatures carved on the *vedikas* around the ancient stupas were intended to provide us with a glimpse of the auspicious scenes of the atmospheric lake.

Such auspicious scenes, as mentioned earlier, are depicted not only on the ceilings but also around the entrances of Indic shrines. As the entrance of the shrine represents the gate of the heaven located beyond the clouds, we expect to see all the objects shown on the ceiling paintings around the shrine entrances as



7.33
Cloud bird on cloud lotus, both designed like *meghapatra*, Bodhgaya, c. 2nd century CE. From A.K. Coomaraswamy, "La Sculpture de Bodhgaya", *Ars Asiatica* 18 (Paris: Les Editions d'Arte et d'Histoire, 1935).

7.34
Pokkharasataka motif, entrance to the Shantipura shrine, Svayambhu hill, Nepal, c. 15th century. Photograph: author.





well. An excellent example of the *pushkarasada* motif in medieval-period Newar art is the scene of the same cloud-lake carved on the high lintel of the wooden entrance of the celebrated Buddhist shrine of Shantipura at the northwest section of the Svayambhu hill in Kathmandu (figure 7.34).

We should also note an ancient graffito (figures 7.35 and 7.36) carved on an upright of the Bharhut railing that shows the meandering foliage-motif superficially chiselled into the stone. This graffito indicates that the immature secondary artist responsible for this work was familiar with the significance of the foliage motif descending from either side of the half-medallion containing the image of a fishtailed *dhara/makara*. In order to emphasize the relationship between the fishtailed creature and the foliage, the graffito artist has carved a “channel” between them – a groove that perforates the rim of the original medallion. This meaningful effort of the artist, however, becomes evident only if we are familiar with the fact that a Sanskrit word for raindrop is *धारंकुरा*, which literally means “a rain-sprout”. According to the *Atharvaveda Parishishta* (64.1.10), most parts of which could be contemporaneous with the Bharhut

sculptures, the “rain-sprouts” resemble the foliage of a blue lotus vine. They fall on the ground when Varuna shakes the flowering vine of the atmosphere. Reasonably therefore, the foliage motif carved on the railing must be the artistic expression of the rain-sprout and blue lotus vine. A similar lotus vine is also carved on the body of the Ashokan elephant to indicate the rain symbolism of the animal (see figure 6.14). This was a widely known subject for several centuries in ancient India and is attested by the appearance of the same *धारंकुरा* motif in many different forms and styles in both sculpture and painting.



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The atmospheric lake is located in the aerial capital of Kuvera, the king of the *yakshas*. The monarch and his subjects travel on the backs of a variety of *vahanas*, which include not only animal-vehicles but also human beings, both male and female. This statement given in the *Atanatiyasutra* (*Dighanikaya* 9.2.7) tallies with the images of *yaksha* and *yakshi* standing on various creatures and men and women, as depicted in the railings of the Bharhut and Sanchi stupas and Mathura sculptures.⁴⁷ Around the 7th century and even later Kuvera continued to be known as *naravahana*, “having a man as a vehicle”.⁴⁸ Moreover, the images of *yakshis*

7.35

Fishtailed *makara* with *धारंकुरा* motif below, Bharhut, c. 2nd century BCE. Photograph courtesy American Institute of Indian Studies (AIIS), Gurgaon.

7.36

Fishtailed *makara* with *धारंकुरा* motif roughly chiselled below, detail of figure 7.35. Photograph courtesy American Institute of Indian Studies (AIIS), Gurgaon.

carved on the wooden struts of Newar temples stand elegantly in *tribhanga* posture neither on the ground nor on a lotus pedestal as one might expect, but on the head and back of male and female figures (figure 7.37), sometimes humorously on the limbs of an old man or old woman. Such an unusual feature indicates their affinity with the iconography of much earlier sculptures of Bharhut and Mathura, which in turn are based on the popular story described in the *Atanatiyasutra*.

The main symbolic feature of stupa architecture is the *yupa-yashti* placed in the middle of the stupa. The similarity between the ritual decoration of the *yupa* mentioned in the *Baudhayana Grihyasutra* and the artistic features of the *vedika* may not be accidental. Just as in the case of the Vedic sacrificial post (*yupa*), the *yupa-yashti* of the Buddhist stupa simultaneously symbolizes both the cosmic pillar and the water pillar or rain-river that flows down from the inverted atmospheric rain pot *varshasthali*, prescribed to be placed on top of the *yupa-yashti* (Chapter 5). As we know from Pali and Sanskrit texts, kings in ancient India and Nepal, in times of severe drought, attempted to solve the problem by performing various

rituals and recitations of mantras while walking along the circumambulation path demarcated by the *vedika* around the stupa.

Thus we conclude that for a proper understanding of the development of Newar culture and artistic heritage, not only linguistic associations but also geographic locations and climatic phenomena deserve proper attention. Like the culture and artistic concepts of most of South Asia, those of the Newars are closely affiliated to the agrarian culture of the subcontinent based on the annual phenomena of aestivation and monsoon. Unlike in Tibet, the religious ritual of rainy season retreat, for instance, is here as practical as in other parts of the subcontinent. If the Newars had migrated from the other side of the Himalaya, they might have adopted the aestivation/monsoon culture, just as the Indo-Iranians did, soon after they settled down in their new homelands. Thus, the monsoonal aspects of Vedic literature, most of which have remained intact throughout the history of South Asian culture, are helpful in investigating not only ancient stone sculptures and paintings from Bharhut, Sanchi, Ajanta, and other important historical sites of the subcontinent, but also the art of the Kathmandu valley. The isolation of the valley has preserved some ancient aspects of aestivation/monsoon culture, easily discernible in the art and culture of the valley even in present times.

7.37
Yakshis standing on male and female figures, Yatkha Baha, Kathmandu, c. 12th century CE. Photograph: author.



Notes

- 1 The recent works on the water fountains of the valley include: Raimund O.A. Becker-Ritterspach, *Water Conduits in the Kathmandu Valley* (New Delhi: Munshiram Manoharlal, 1995); its review by Mary Shepherd Slusser, *Artibus Asiae* 56.1/2 (1996), pp. 177–81; Sukra Sagar Shrestha, “Tusa Hiti”, *Ancient Nepal: Journal of the Department of Archaeology* 139 (June 1996), pp. 1–10; Gudrun Bühnemann, “17th Century Tantric Iconography of Nepal: New Research on the ‘Royal Bath’ in Patan”, *Orientalia* 39.6 (September 2008), pp. 88–95.
- 2 Kamal Prakash Malla, “Linguistic Archaeology of the Nepal Valley: A Preliminary Report”, *Kailas* 8.1–2, (1981), pp. 5–23.

3 Gautama V. Vajracharya, "Nepali Inscriptions, Transcribed, Translated and Interpreted", in Pratapaditya Pal, *Himalayas: An Aesthetic Adventure* (Chicago: The Art Institute of Chicago in association with University of California Press and Mapin, 2003), p. 284.

4 Dhanavajra Vajracharya and Kamal P. Malla, eds., *The Gopalarajavamsavali* (Wiesbaden: Franz Steiner Verlag, 1985), folio 27 *kha*. This text also refers to the village as Navakwatha, which also means new fort (folios 38 *kha*, 40 *ka*).

5 Vajracharya, "Nepali Inscriptions", p. 284.

6 Alex Wayman, "Climactic Times in Indian Mythology and Religion", *History of Religions*, 4.2 (Winter 1965), pp. 302–03.

7 According to the late 14th-century Newari translation of *Amarakosha*, the Newari word for Sanskrit *vishuvat*, equinox, is *vishaka* or *vishika* (*Newari Lexicon*, <http://www.panactive.com/newarilexicon/source.html>). Exactly the same words are used in the late 16th- and 17th-century Newari inscriptions and diary called *thyasaphu* for the modern-day festival of Bisket or Vishvayatra, see for example *Purnima* 30.2 (Srvana vs 2062, June/July 2005), pp. 34–35. Malla-period inscriptions at the Hanumandhoka palace inform us that during the medieval period not only Bhaktapur but also Kathmandu celebrated the day as Vishvayatra and erected a pole near Duimaju shrine in modern-day Tundikhel. Gautama Vajracharya, *Hanumandhoka Rajadarabara* (Kirtipur: Institute of Nepal and Asian Studies, 1975), pp. 154–55. Vishvayatra is actually the re-Sanskritization of Bisket, which in turn is the *apabhrahmsa* (derivation) of Sanskrit *vishuvat*. For the popular story of the Newar festival, readers may refer to Mary M. Anderson, *The Festivals of Nepal* (Calcutta: Rupa, 1988), pp. 41–49.

8 Arthur Anthony Macdonell and Arthur Berriedale Keith, eds., *Vedic Index of Names and Subjects* (Delhi: Motilal Banarsidass, 1967), vol. 1, pp. 422–26.

9 In ancient Newari, *te* means east. This we know from several examples such as Teta Dhvaka (eastern city gate), Teta Thur (eastern stupa in Patan), Tendokhyala (modern Tundikhel, the eastern open area in Kathmandu), Temdo Vihara (modern Tebahal, a Buddhist monastery in the eastern section of the old city of Kathmandu), and Tegvala (eastern locality

of a town). Reference to the last word can be found in both ancient and medieval period inscriptions of Nepal. Dhanavajra Vajracharya, *Licchavikalaka Abhilekha* (Kirtipur: Institute of Nepal and Asian Studies, 1973), pp. 342, 544; Ramaji Tevari et al., eds., *Abhilekha-Samgraha*, vol. 9 (Kathmandu: Samsodhana-Mandala, 1963), pp. 24–25. Bilingual inscriptions found inside the temple of Changu hill refer to the hill as Purvashikhara, "eastern hilltop" in Sanskrit, and Tekhri or Tekhr in Newari. In these inscriptions, the main deity inside the temple is designated Tekhribhattaraka, "the great god of the eastern hilltop". Mohana Prasada Khanala, *Changu Narayanaka Aitihasika Samagri* (Kirtipur: Institute of Nepal and Asian Studies, 1983), pp. 153, 160. Many Newar towns and villages have a locality called Tyagal, which is indeed the modern version of Tegvala. Due to the constant expansion of residential areas, Tegvala or Tyagal is not always in the eastern part of the town any more. But it was an ancient Newar custom to have a phallic icon, later identified as Shivalinga, in the eastern quarter of a Newar town. Patan Tyagal Tol, for instance, has a rudimentary Shivalinga shrine. An 11th-century inscription carved on the pedestal of a Shaivite sculpture found in the vicinity of the shrine refers to the region as Tegvala. Tevari et al., eds., *Abhilekha-Samgraha*, vol. 9, pp. 24–25. Moreover, unpublished medieval inscriptions in the vicinity of the well-known Pashupatinath temple designate the location as Tyagvala and the entire town is still called Gvala, known to Nepali-speaking people as Deopatan. Likewise, the ancient Newari name for the Vagmati river survives in Tekhu Dobhan, the confluence of the Vagmati and Vishnumati. In classical Newari, Tekhu or Tekho, "the eastern river", is regularly used for the Vagmati river.

Already in the 14th century the word *te* was replaced by another classical Newari word *va* or *vam*, and, therefore, Changu hill was then also known as Vannchangu, eastern Changu. Vajracharya and Malla, eds., *The Gopalarajavamsavali*, folio 30 *kha*. Neither of these synonyms for east is used in modern Newari, but they clearly indicate the three layers of development of the Newari language.

Likewise, the Newari word *ya*, according to the Newari translations of the *Amarakosha*, means

west. In modern Newari, it regularly turns into *i*, as exemplified by Yachangu, modern day Ichangu (western Changu Narayana), the celebrated Yatumbahara currently known as Itumbahara, “western well monastery”, and Yakhapukhu or Ikhapukhu for the western pond in Kathmandu, now filled and occupied by residences and school grounds. The western pond was a beautiful lotus pond located at the western limits of Kathmandu city. The most recent work on classical Newari is Kamal P. Malla et al., eds., *A Dictionary of Classical Newari, Compiled from Manuscript Sources* (Kathmandu: Cwasa Pasa, 2000). However, this dictionary may not include some of the classical Newari words mentioned in this chapter. The early Newari translations of the *Amarakosha* are very important for investigating classical Newari. This was realized for the first time in Gautama Vajracharya, “*Nevari bhasako tamanga bhasa tatha limbu bhasasamgako sadrsya*”, *Purnima* 1.2 (vs 2021), pp. 43–49. Many classical Newari words such as *kemo* (husband), *lani* (moon), and *li* (bow) are studied in this work as important non-Sanskritic terms that are similar to the words of other Tibeto-Burman languages of Nepal. Most of the words are found in the Newari translation of the *Amarakosha*. Unexpectedly, however, more than a hundred such significant words are missing in the dictionary. Furthermore, popular Newar folk etymology is incorporated in the dictionary as acceptable etymological explanation (e.g. the idea that *nakhata* is a festival because it literally means “eating” or “festival of eating”). In reality, the meaning of *nakhata* as a festival originated from the ancient South Asian custom of *nakkhatta-kila* or simply *nakkhatta*, a Pali version of Sanskrit *nakshatra* denoting “a celebration of the beginning of a lunar mansion or constellation of new month, hence any kind of festival or festivity”. T.W. Rhys Davids and William Stede, eds., *The Pali Text Society's Pali-English Dictionary* (London: The Pali Text Society, 1986), p. 344. Such words deserve special attention because they elucidate not only the development of language but also the cultural and visual heritage of the valley. This is not, however, a proper occasion to provide the readers with a list of Pali words in classical Newari.

10 Gautama V. Vajracharya, “Elements of Newar

Buddhist Art: *Circle of Bliss* – A Review Article”, <http://www.asianart.com/articles/circle/index.html>.

11 Vajracharya, *Licchavikalaka Abhilekha*, pp. 438–39.

12 In northern India the practice of arranging a frogs’ wedding procession as a rainmaking ritual is still in vogue. Thus, it would not be surprising if the worship of frogs is also prevalent somewhere in India.

13 Vajracharya, *Licchavikalaka Abhilekha*, pp. 214, 217.

14 Gerard Toffin, *Newar Society: City, Village and Periphery* (Kathmandu: Social Science Baha, 2007), pp. 86–87.

15 It is a well-known fact that *upavita* originally meant “a shawl-like garment or hide worn diagonally covering the left shoulder”. Scholars have presented textual evidence to support this view. A phrase from *Taittiriyaanyaka* 2.1.1 may suffice: *ajinam vasa va daksinata upaviya*, “having worn a hide or a garment diagonally (*upaviya*) from the right side”. Such a manner of wearing a shawl in *upavita* style is still prevalent among the Newars in a religious context.

16 *Atharvaveda* 11.5; W. Caland, ed., *Vaikhānasagṛhyasūtram and Vaikhānasadharmasūtram* (New Delhi: Meharchand Lachhmandas, reprint 1989), pp. 22–24.

17 Readers will find more about the *vahla/vala* in following pages.

18 Gautama V. Vajracharya, “Threefold Intimacy: The Recent Discovery of an Outstanding Nepalese Portrait Painting”, *Orientalism* 34.4 (April 2003), p. 42.

19 *Thusa* is a classical Newari word for a bull, as we know from the Newari translation of the *Amarakosha* (see *Newari Lexicon* <http://www.panactive.com/newarilexicon/source.html>). Due to the language barrier, Nepali-speaking people including the authors of the *Bhasha-Vamshavali* mistakenly refer to the fountain as *Tusa Hiti*, which has created widespread confusion both in Western and Nepali writing. Newar intellectuals of Patan, however, seem to remember the classical word and its correct meaning. For instance, Hariram Joshi, a Newar scholar from Patan, shows his familiarity with the actual name of the fountain and relates it to the original appearance of the fountain with a figure of a bull. See Shrestha, “*Tusa Hiti*”, p. 4.

20 Vajracharya, *Licchavikalaka Abhilekha*, pp. 208–10.

- 21 Tevari et al., eds., *Abhilekha-samgraha*, vol. 2, p. 10; D.R. Regmi, *Medieval Nepal*, 4 parts (Calcutta: K.L. Mukhopadhyay, 1966), part III, p. 7, inscription xiii.
- 22 Vasudeva S. Agrawala, *The Deeds of Harsha, Being a Cultural Study of Bana's Harsacarita* (Varanasi: Prithvi Prakashan, 1969), p. 20.
- 23 The word *dasara* (Sanskrit *dashahara*) is reminiscent of the Vedic system of the enumeration of time, in which ten days, rather than seven days, makes a calendar period.
- 24 Michael Witzel, "Substrate Languages in Old Indo-Aryan (Rgvedic, Middle and Late Vedic)", *Electronic Journal of Vedic Studies* 5.1 (September 1999), p. 14. <http://www.ejvs.laurasianacademy.com/ejvs0501/ejvs0501a.txt>.
- 25 Vajracharya, *Licchavikalaka Abhilekha*, p. 368.
- 26 Vajracharya and Malla, *Gopalarajavamsavali*, 24 ka, 31 ka, 58 ka. The editors of the text believed that Valavala is the Valkhu rivulet because they thought the shrine of the goddess Valavala is located in Kirtipur (*kirtibhagatapura* 24 ka). But if we study the related passages carefully it becomes evident that Valavala is indeed a mystic river associated with multiple sources of water – not only fountains (*panalika*, *yiti* 31 ka and 58 ka), but also wells (*kupa* 31 ka) and lotus ponds (*pvashkarani*, *kha* 24 ka 58 ka) and *dharas* (*makara* fountains). King Shivadeva, for instance, successfully controlled the Valavala river; as a result, he was able to adorn his kingdom with fountains and wells in multiple locations (*Shivadevasa kritya*, *valavalanadi bandhaniyam*, *panalika kupa desha sthane sthane shobha krita*). If Valavala is the minor Valkhu rivulet it would not have been associated with the wells and ponds of the entire kingdom of Shivadeva. It is however true that the Valkhu is also a source of water named after the same onomatopoeic word.
- 27 F.B.J. Kuiper, "The Genesis of a Linguistic Area", *Indo-Iranian Journal* 10 (1967–68), p. 95. According to Kuiper the Vedic expression *bal iti* has to be derived from pre-Vedic Indic language because *iti* is a technical element used for quoting foreign words, particularly onomatopoeiac.
- 28 Witzel, "Substrate Languages in Old Indo-Aryan", p. 14.
- 29 *Hluti* is a classical Newari word for a natural lake with fountains. However, it is used not only for a lake but also for the fountains that turn into rivers. Literally, it may mean "a bathing place".
- 30 Witzel, "Substrate Languages in Old Indo-Aryan", p. 14.
- 31 Since I did not have detailed digital photographs of the painting, in earlier work I mistakenly read the label inscription as *sipura dhara*, Vajracharya, "Nepali Inscriptions", p. 284.
- 32 Mary Shepherd Slusser and Gautama Vajracharya, "Some Nepalese Stone Sculptures: A Reappraisal within Their Cultural and Historical Context", *Artibus Asiae* 35.1–2 (1973), pp. 88–125.
- 33 Ibid.
- 34 The right section of the Philadelphia Museum painting shows three lakes fed by the Sihluti river. The first lake closer to the fountain is occupied by recumbent Shiva. His complexion is white and he wears snakes. The second lake is the abode of blue Bhairava holding a *damaru* (small drum) and reclining on the water. He is identified by a label inscription as *shri bhairava*. The third lake belongs to Sarasvati who is represented in a seated position and playing the musical instrument *vina*. Her identity is also confirmed by a label inscription.
- 35 In the original version of this chapter published in *asianart.com*, to enhance my view that *vahla* or *vala* is a Newari word for foetus, I quoted the following phrase from Kashinath Tamot, ed., *Putrapautradibodhini*, *Amarakosaya Nepalabhāsa Tika*, Ne. Sam. 501 (Kathmandu: Pasamuna, 1983), p. 64: "*garbha*, *garbhasa congū*, *vala*". Recently, Ian Alsop, the editor of *asianart.com*, kindly sent me digital photographs of the *Amarakosha* manuscript in the National Archives, Kathmandu. After I examined the relevant photograph, I see that the final word in the text cited above, i.e. *vala*, should, in fact, be read as either *vala* or *bala*. It should not be, however, readily assumed that Newari *vala* derives from Sanskrit *bala*, child. It is the close similarity in both the spelling and the pronunciation of the Newari and Sanskrit words that resulted in the divine foetus/seed known to the ancient Newars as *wahlah* or *vala* being incorporated into the new Hindu iconography as Bala (Child) Nilakantha. Nowhere in Sanskrit literature is this Hindu god with blue throat described as a child. Nevertheless, *Hluti* or *Balaju* has continued

to be associated with divine seed. According to Buddhist tradition, the ceremonial ritual of bathing in the Hluti pond on the morning of the full moon in the month of Chaitra is significant because it is on that day, in the middle of the Kathmandu valley lake, that Manjushri planted the seed of the giant lotus, now hidden beneath the Svayambhu Stupa, upon which the Cosmic Buddha continues to meditate to this very day.

36 Vajracharya, *Licchavikalaka Abhilekha*, pp. 320–21.

37 For clarity of thinking, we should note that the images associated with this psychological impact are not logically related to the concept of atmospheric gestation that begins in autumn and ends with the delivery of the rain child at the beginning of the monsoon. The puranic legend of Vishnu is however partially related to the vedic story of Hiranyagarbha, the child of the rain clouds. We seldom expect logic to remain intact in the secondary development of the legend.

38 I am grateful to Ian Alsop and Kashinath Tamot for providing me with much-needed information regarding the label inscription that identifies the mother goddess of Kirtipur as “Dharati Mata”.

39 Mary Shepherd Slusser, “Nepali Sculptures – New Discoveries”, in Pratapaditya Pal, ed., *Aspects of Indian Art* (Leiden: E.J. Brill, 1972), pp. 98–101, pl. Llb.

40 J. Gonda, *Aspects of Early Visnuism* (Delhi: Motilal Banarasidass, 1969), p. 218.

41 Ibid., pp. 220–21.

42 Slusser and Vajracharya, “Some Nepalese Stone Sculptures”, p. 121.

43 Poonam Gurung, *Bungamati, The Life World of a Newar Community Explored through the Natural and Social Life of Water* (Norway: University of Bergen, 2000), p. 87. www.univisjon.no/eden/images/bunga.pdf.

44 For an illustration see Anne Vergati, *Art et Société au Népal* (Paris: Picard, 2005), p. 16. The above-mentioned Buddhist scroll painting from Nepal supports my views on drought and fertility. I was not, however, familiar with the details of the painting until 2008 when, in a talk Katherine Paul gave at the Asian Art Museum, San Francisco, she drew my attention to the meaningful juxtapositions, such as fighting with drought and lovemaking with rain, in the

narrative scenes of the scroll painting. I appreciate her observation.

45 Gonda, *Aspects of Early Visnuism*, pp. 81–82.

46 A.K. Coomaraswamy, *Yaksas* (New Delhi: Munshiram Manoharlal, 1971), part 2, p. 32.

47 An excellent work showing the relationship between the architecture of ancient Buddhist stupas and the atmospheric region of the *yakshas* as described in the *Atanatiyasutra*, is an article by Peter Skilling, “The Raksa Literature of the Sravakayana”, *Journal of the Pali Text Society* 16 (1962), pp. 109–82.

48 This iconographic feature of the king of the *yakshas* is perhaps based on the reality of life within palaces. As we know from a Nepali drama *Premapinda*, based on the story of the Ranas of the 19th century, the royals moved around the palace on the backs of their servants.

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